

believe that he once owned a large, successful marketing company. But overspending and chronic credit card use eventually landed Paul half a million dollars in debt, with the government forcing him into bankruptcy. By the end of his spending and debt spree, his marriage was over, creditors were calling day and night, and he was practically homeless. After he spent the night on his brother's couch, his brother suggested Paul go to Debtors Anonymous to get some help. Left with no other option, he very reluctantly attended his first meeting. There, he slowly began to turn things around. Paul realized he viewed money as power, and when he felt powerless, he spent more money he didn't have, in hopes of avoiding that feeling. Then, terrified of exposing himself as a fraud, he frantically surrounded himself with symbols of success to keep the charade going as long as possible. He realized that this had to change completely, or he'd face jail—or worse, the kind of despair that leads to suicide.

Another member, a small woman in her sixties, Diane, admitted that for her, it felt better to put something on a credit card than it did to pay cash. Using her card, she said, made her feel like part of an elite club. She said it felt “magical.” As if she'd gotten away with something. And that's precisely the effect credit card marketers are after. For Diane, paradoxically—tragically—the only way to quell the fear of having no money was to spend money she didn't really have. Eventually, she depleted her savings and cashed in her retirement funds. Then she began to beg, borrow, and steal from friends and family to keep up appearances. But soon the banks and the creditors caught up with her. In the end, she, too, was broke, homeless, and alone.

Listening to these harrowing stories, I realized that these weren't bad people. Not at all. They were clearly intelligent people who'd made very bad decisions about money and were facing the consequences. But what became apparent was the powerful allure of money and how easy it was for all these people to believe that power comes from money itself, rather than from how money is deployed.

After the meeting's close, I hung around for a while, greeting the attendees—young hipsters, middle-aged teachers, former executives—all of whom had shared their stories with me that day. I shook hands